



Nehru, a Political Life, with complete access to the papers.

SHARM EL-SHEIKH

A joint statement by Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and Pakistani counterpart hit the headlines after allegations that India has played into Pakistan's hands by agreeing to include the Baluchistan issue in the statement. Fingers were pointed at the then foreign secretary Shiv Shankar Menon over the "bad drafting" of the statement. Now the MEA has approached the Delhi High Court over the CIC direction to open details of preparatory files to the applicant, Subhash Aggarwal, an RTI activist.

state William Rogers on October 5, 1972, were available but refused to disclose them, citing a confidentiality clause.

EMERGENCY Most of the documents related to the Emergency are beyond the reach of scholars. The report of the L.P. Singh Committee on the misuse of intelligence agencies and the Central Bureau of Investigation during the Emergency between 1975 and 1977 is

still not accessible. Singh, a former home secretary, is no more.

NEHRU FAMILY PAPERS

Many papers of India's first prime minister, Jawaharlal Nehru, and Prime Minister Indira Gandhi remain in the control of the family. Very few historians have access to these documents which narrate the story of governance in modern India. Judith M. Brown, an Oxford professor, wrote

main in the control of his descendants. The official correspondence of Indira Gandhi as prime minister has not been shown to anyone outside the family," says historian Ramachandra Guha. As a result, any effort to research the policies of the Government between 1947 and 1964, between 1966 and 1977, and between 1980 and 1984 will be only partially successful. "There is no distinction between a politician's private papers and the government's papers. When researching, it'll be pure luck if you find what you need," says Patrick French, the author of *Liberty Or Death: India's Journey To Independence and Division*.

Pushed to the wall, Apri wrote to the young Nehru-Gandhi scion, Rahul Gandhi, last year: "You are young and modern, you should understand the importance of opening the archives, in particular the Nehru papers. It is good for India." A reply is still awaited.

The Public Records Act 1993 and the RTI Act are filled with loopholes and vague provisions. While the RTI Act stip-

ulates that information from records under exempted categories be made available after 20 years, the lock-in period according to the Public Records Act is 25 years. The irony is that the manual governing the declassification process itself is a classified document. Unlike the RTI Act, there is no penal provision for officials who delay transferring records to the NAI. There is no appellate authority to take on erring departments.

Nobody abuses a catch-all term like national security with such enthusiasm as the bureaucracy. The tragedy is that the history of republican India is often constructed from unofficial papers. Years from now, somebody trying to know about the policy decisions taken on the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act will get only a handful of documents. "How can someone work on these subjects when papers related to these policies are not made public?" asks social historian Mukul Kesavan. While the CIA declassifies every 15 days, India's Research and Analysis Wing

MUSHIRUL HASAN
Director General of NAI



“The flow of documents and records from various ministries has been slow. It will be our priority to access them and make them accessible to the public at large.”

CLAUDE APRI
Historian and author of *Fate of Tibet*



“The tragedy is that 63 years after Independence, Indian scholars have to base their research on foreign archives. We are unable to write history from the Indian point of view.”

(R&AW) is yet to declassify any document.

When Chandrachur Ghose, an activist campaigning for a comprehensive declassification policy, approached R&AW last February asking about its declassification policy, it said that the organisation is exempt from disclosure unless the details sought relate to charges of corruption or human rights violations.

Former director, research and policy division, home ministry, K.S. Subramanian, while researching a book on internal security, was shocked to find much of the information related to the dismissal of Communist Government in Kerala in 1959 and the arrest of Sheikh Abdullah by Nehru in 1953 still classified. "Our security agencies still live in a culture of unwanted secrecy unlike foreign agencies, like MI5, which has published its official history. This has resulted in poor inter-disciplinary research on issues like O," he says. Unless the bureaucracy discards this paranoid vigilance, it will be destined to relive in the mistakes of the past. ■